Esterlin Jerez Paulino

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SKILLS

- **Programming Languages:** Java, JavaScript, Python, SQL
- **Frameworks & Tools:** React, Next.js, Vite, Express, Django, Node.js, Tailwind CSS
- **Databases:** MongoDB, PostgreSQL, Firebase
- **Languages:** Fluent in Spanish

EXPERIENCE

Handshake November 2025 – Present
AI Research Associate

- Evaluated 1,500+ AI outputs across text, image, and audio modalities to flag factual errors and edge cases, enabling the ML team to refine training data and update evaluation criteria, improving pass rates on internal benchmarks
- Applied systematic testing methodologies to surface recurring failure modes across the training pipeline, improving data integrity and consistency for large-scale dataset evaluation.
- Produced structured quality reports on model limitations that directly informed rubric updates and standardized evaluation practices across modalities.

Headstarter July 2024 – September 2024
Software Engineer Fellowship

- Led backend development and frontend integration for AI-powered web apps on a **MERN/Firebase** stack, delivering 6 production features to 100+ users in 3 weeks and reducing average API response time by 35%.
- Collaborated with a team of 4, owning backend architecture decisions while contributing across **React**, **Next.js**, **Firebase**, **Clerk**, and **Stripe** to ship features end to end.
- Ranked top 3 out of hundreds of teams on idea, complexity, and business viability, pitching TimeMesh to Nabeel Alamgir (co-founder, Lunchbox) and securing a $1,000 investment offer.

PROJECTS

Notes Assistant - AI-Powered Study Platform | Team of 1 GitHub | Site
Full-Stack Developer September 2025

- Built a full-stack platform that ingests PDFs, DOCX files, and raw text and generates AI-powered summaries, flashcards, quizzes, and action items via the **OpenAI API**.
- Engineered a text chunking pipeline that splits large documents into ~3,000-character segments and summarizes each chunk, preventing token overflows and enabling reliable processing of documents 10x larger than the base model context window.
- Designed structured prompt templates with JSON parsing and per-format error recovery for four output types, cutting generation failures by 60% and ensuring reliable structured responses even on noisy or incomplete documents.
- Implemented **JWT-based authentication** and **MongoDB** indexing to support fast document retrieval and session-scoped access across users.
- Utilized: **React, Vite, Node.js, Express, MongoDB, JWT, OpenAI API**

TimeMesh - Multi-Calendar Sharing Web App | Team of 4 GitHub | Site
Full-Stack Developer September 2024

- Owned backend API development for a **Django/PostgreSQL** platform serving 400+ users, designing REST endpoints and schemas for multi-user event ownership and permissions, cutting calendar load times by 30% and enabling real-time updates.
- Built ICS calendar import for Google, Outlook, and Apple calendars, reducing average onboarding time from 10 minutes of manual setup to under 90 seconds and increasing completed sign-ups by 25%.
- Integrated **OpenRouter-powered AI** to surface personalized time-management suggestions and implemented **Google OAuth** for seamless, zero-friction authentication.
- Utilized: **React, Django, PostgreSQL, Tailwind, Google OAuth, OpenRouter**

EDUCATION

New Jersey City University | Jersey City, NJ
Bachelor of Science in Computer Science, Minor in Digital Marketing Graduated May 2025

- Honors & Awards: Dean's List – Spring 2022, Spring 2024, Spring 2025

LEADERSHIP & AFFILIATIONS

CodePath | Remote | *Student Mentor & Event Coordinator* June 2024 – Present

- Mentored students with technical guidance and career advice while hosting networking events to build community connections and support